

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Food safety after power loss

RECOVERY / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Without power, a refrigerator keeps food safe for about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours and a half-full freezer about 24 hours. Never taste food to test safety. Use official discard guidance and a thermometer.

Do now.

- ☐ **Note the time**
01 Record when power failed and avoid opening cold storage.
- ☐ **Use temperatures**
02 Check appliance and food temperatures when safe; appearance and smell do not prove safety.
- ☐ **Discard risky food**
03 After 4 hours without power or another cold source, discard refrigerated perishables such as meat, eggs and leftovers.
- ☐ **Check frozen food**
04 Food with ice crystals or at 40°F or below can generally be refrozen or cooked; use official food-specific charts.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Track the time power stopped and use a fridge thermometer if available. If time or temperature is unknown, discard suspect perishable food and use shelf-stable food. Spend scarce fuel on safe water and essential cooking rather than trying to rescue unsafe food.

Watch for.

Do not serve questionable food to people or pets.

People & practical needs.

Plan a safe meal for each person before using the most vulnerable refrigerated food. Include infant feeding and food allergies. Keep the food decision separate from medicine storage: a clinician or pharmacist must advise on a specific medicine.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Clean appliances and replace spoiled supplies. Keep thermometers available before the next outage.

Check the next usable option

Clean appliances and replace spoiled supplies. Keep thermometers available before the next outage.

When the first option is unavailable

Track the time power stopped and use a fridge thermometer if available. If time or temperature is unknown, discard suspect perishable food and use shelf-stable food. Spend scarce fuel on safe water and essential cooking rather than trying to rescue unsafe food.

Questions in the field.

Should I open the refrigerator to check?

Keep doors closed as much as possible. Use the outage time and a reliable food thermometer rather than repeated inspection. Record the temperature if it can be checked without prolonged opening; smell and taste do not prove safety.

What can move to a cooler?

Use a clean insulated container and enough ice or cold packs to maintain a safe temperature. Keep raw meat separated from ready-to-eat food. If safe cooling cannot be maintained, switch to shelf-stable food rather than stretching a doubtful supply.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Food safety after power loss · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/food-safety/foods/keep-food-safe-after-emergency.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/food-safety-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.